PRINCIPLE III: AI-ASSISTED LANGUAGE EDUCATION SHOULD BE PURPOSEFUL

Guideline 6

Create expanded language learning opportunities

About this guideline

The question of whether artificial intelligence adds value to language teaching and learning requires a qualitative judgment of what AI use makes possible that was either impossible or pragmatically impractical previously. A useful starting point in this judgment is whether AI use replicates existing practice or genuinely expands what teachers and learners can do. What counts as desirable change is context-dependent and ideologically contested (Alim & Paris, 2017; Hornberger & Johnson, 2007; Pennycook, 2010), so Guideline 6 does not focus on examples of promising use; rather, it explores how the intentional use of artificial intelligence can create affordances that expand learner opportunity, enhance learner agency and increase the teachers' capacity. These criteria are not a checklist: they can be applied together or separately depending on the context and goals of language education in any specific setting.

Expanding **learner opportunity** involves the use of artificial intelligence to generate learning affordances that were previously unavailable or prohibitively resource-intensive. Examples of such affordances include providing opportunities for communicative practice in languages for which human talking partners are scarce, and generating personalised feedback at a scale that would be impractical for most teachers. The key diagnostic is that the use of AI in such cases involves the transformation of the language learning experience, as opposed to the superficial or tokenistic reproduction, in a faster and less costly format, of activities that already existed, such as drill exercises and closed-form questions. The speed with which generative AI can generate drill-type items (for example, vocabulary practice or multiple-choice questions) should be weighed against their variable language-learning potential, ensuring that such exercises serve clear pedagogical purposes and complement, rather than replace, higher-involvement and meaning-focused work.

A second criterion is the impact of artificial intelligence on **learner agency**, i.e., their capacity to direct, shape and take ownership of their learning. The transformative use of artificial intelligence involves practices and resources that support learners in setting their own learning goals, evaluating their own output and making meaningful choices about how and what to learn. This is to be contrasted with usages of artificial intelligence which constrain agency, either by algorithmically channelling learners through pre-structured learning pathways or by foregrounding easily measurable outcomes. What differentiates transformative use from mere automation is the degree of control that learners enjoy over their learning goals, process and outcomes. This is especially important for language education, which is inextricably linked to considerations of identity, motivation and willingness to communicate,

all of which may be impacted by the use of AI (Fathi et al., 2024; Liu & Reinders, 2025; Yuan & Liu, 2025).

Turning to the teachers, the third criterion for the intentional transformation of the language learning experience concerns what AI makes possible for teachers. When thinking of **teacher capacity**, the focus is not just on time saved but on the expansion of their pedagogical horizons. Automation of well-specified, low-judgement tasks (e.g., first-pass feedback, routine differentiation) is valuable insofar as it frees teacher time for work that is difficult to automate responsibly: interpreting learner trajectories, building classroom relationships and orchestrating dialogic interaction. However, the use of AI to merely replicate what teachers already did does not genuinely expand capacity in the sense discussed here. AI becomes valuable when it helps teachers notice what they would otherwise miss, explore new pedagogical approaches or design learning experiences that would otherwise have been beyond their reach. Transformative education, in this sense, involves making teachers more capable and more thoughtful practitioners.

Did you know?

AI can help achieve learning goals that would otherwise be out of reach. For example:

- **Richer feedback loops**: AI can provide learners with a first layer of feedback on written or spoken output. This can free teachers to focus on deeper, teacher-led analysis. Subject to legal constraints (see Guideline 1), such a hybrid division of labour can drive a genuine refocusing of language lessons, away from recognition and functional literacy, and towards critical literacy and metalinguistic insight.
- **Challenging normative monolingualism**: AI can be leveraged to push back against the monolingual norm in language classrooms by building connections to the full linguistic repertoires of plurilingual learners. One way to do this would be to translate content to and from the learners' other languages, which would have been impractical for teachers in very diverse classrooms.
- **More cross-lingual work**: The use of AI in language education enables scaffolding that leverages the students' linguistic repertoires, which would have been impossible in the past if the teacher did not speak or understand the L1s of the students.
- **Learner-centred syllabus design**: AI can support a shift from top-down textbook-based instruction to context-sensitive, bottom-up syllabus design. This can generate customised materials based on learners' strengths, needs, and interests.

Did you know?

The Substitution, Augmentation, Modification or Redefinition (SAMR) framework (Puentedura, 2006) describes digital innovation as leading to one of four outcomes:

- When technology **substitutes** an existing task, there is no functional change. This can happen when an AI application writes multiple-choice tasks for grammar practice.
- When technology **augments** an existing task, there is some functional improvement, but the nature of the task remains the same. A teacher using AI to generate multiple versions of the same grammar exercise is still operating within the traditional paradigm, but AI makes differentiation faster and more scalable.
- When the new technology allows for the substantial redesign of an existing task, this leads to **modification**. An instance of this might be when learners use a conversational agent that dynamically adjusts to their interest and linguistic profile, rather than using a scripted dialogue.
- When the new technology enables the creation of new tasks that were inconceivable without it, this leads to task **redefinition**. This could involve working with AI tools to co-construct individualised learning trajectories by selecting authentic texts (e.g., podcasts, news articles) suited to the learners' level and interests, and having the AI application generate vocabulary support, comprehension questions, and follow-up tasks.

References

Alim H. S. and Paris D. (2017), "What is culturally sustaining pedagogy and why does it matter?", in Paris D. and Alim H. S. (eds), *Culturally sustaining pedagogies: teaching and learning for justice in a changing world*, pp. 1-21, Teachers College Press, New York.

Fathi J., Rahimi M. and Derakhshan A. (2024), "Improving EFL learners' speaking skills and willingness to communicate via artificial intelligence-mediated interactions", *System*, Vol. 121, Article 103254, available at: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2024.103254.

Hornberger N. H. and Johnson D. C. (2007), "Slicing the onion ethnographically: layers and spaces in multilingual language education policy and practice", *TESOL Quarterly*, Vol. 41, Issue 3, pp. 509-532, available at: https://doi.org/10.1002/j.1545-7249.2007.tb00083.x.

Liu M. and Reinders H. (2025), "Do AI chatbots impact motivation? Insights from a preliminary longitudinal study", *System*, Vol. 128, Article 103544, available at: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2024.103544.

Pennycook A. (2010), *Language as a local practice*, Routledge, London.

Puentedura R. R. (2006), *Transformation, technology, and education*, available at: http://hippasus.com/resources/tte/, accessed 12 October 2026.

Yuan L. and Liu X. (2025), "The effect of artificial intelligence tools on EFL learners' engagement, enjoyment, and motivation", *Computers in Human Behavior*, Vol. 162, Article 108474, available at: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2024.108474.

Competences and reflection questions

6.1 I can use AI to transform language learning experiences

Descriptor: *To what extent do the AI-assisted tasks I design transform the language learning experience?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What is one example of a learning opportunity you created using AI that would otherwise not be feasible in your classroom or learning context? In what ways have students benefited from this?
- What would be lost if I removed AI from a task entirely?
- How do the AI-supported activities I use complement meaning-focused work? What pedagogical purposes do they serve beyond efficiency?
- What are the learning outcomes that my AI-supported activities serve, and how well do they align with my instructional goals?

6.2 I can use AI in ways that support the agency of language learners

Descriptor: *To what extent do the AI-assisted tasks I design increase learner agency?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Do the AI tools I use open up choices for learners, or do they channel them through pre-structured pathways?
- How much control do learners have over their goals, process and outcomes?
- How might the AI tools I use affect learners' sense of ownership over their language learning?

6.3 I can improve my teacher capacity through the use of AI

Descriptor: *To what extent do the AI-assisted tasks I design improve my teacher capacity?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How am I using the time that is saved by delegating aspects of my work to artificial intelligence?
- In what ways might AI help me notice things about my learners or my practice that I would otherwise have missed?
- Which of the AI tools I use are helping me do new things as a language teacher, and which ones are helping me do the same things more efficiently?